

The Dat-e Adolescence Prevention Program Protocol: A Cluster Randomized control Trial

Trial registration: 0575-N-14 (Andalusia Ethic Code)

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Abstract:

International and national studies on dating violence have concluded about the higher involvement of adolescents and youths in comparison to adult couples. At the same time, prevention programs have resulted more successful in adolescent population than in older ages, yielding promising results regarding the reduction of aggressive behaviour. However, despite these encouraging results, evidence-based universal prevention programs are still scarce among the scientific community, particularly in Spain. This project aims to contribute to the body of knowledge of evidence-based interventions developing, implementing and evaluating the efficacy of a Cluster-Randomized Control Trial Dating Violence Prevention Program. The program will integrate the characteristics and peculiarities of the phenomenon when it happens in the teenage years; risk and protective factors of dating violence will be considered and included in the design of the intervention program; the program will involve school member staff and will be partially sustained on peer-led learning. The results of this study will contribute to increasing the number of evaluated prevention programs to reduce dating violence in adolescence, which may be used by teachers and

policymakers. By doing this, the project is therefore expected to contribute to the scientific and educational community with a psychoeducational model that could be incorporated into the educational policies.

Introduction

Dating violence can be considered “an aggressive behaviour be it verbal, psychological, physical, sexual or via new technologies which occurs in adolescents romantic relationships more or less long-lasting. This phenomenon is characterized for being primarily contextual and reciprocal, it can be considered a subtype of Intimate Partner Violence (1) and have turned into a global public health problem (2), which calls for the development of evidence-based intervention programs.

To date, evidence-based programs have mainly been carried out in the United States and Canada; and they are still scarce across Europe and South America (3). particularly in Spain. Studies developed in our country have shown that prevalence rates of dating violence are similar to those reported in international studies (4-8). However, there is no tradition on Evidence-based interventions programs on dating violence. In consequence, there are few available programs and they are characterized by poor methodological quality, so it is difficult to draw conclusions on this subject. Thus, programs vary in the aims (8-11), in length, lasting from one session (12) to 14 (13), and in methodological design, this being one of the biggest concerns and the primary obstacle when it comes to evaluating their efficacy (14). At this respect, some do not include control groups (15, 13) and others used very small samples (16). In sum, none of the programs adopted a RCTs; meaning that today we cannot be sure about the efficacy of dating violence prevention programs in Spain.

Aims

Starting from this literature, the aim of this study will be to develop a school-based prevention program aimed at preventing dating violence in adolescence and to assess its efficacy using a cluster randomized control trial.

According to previous literature, we hypothesized that the program will reduce dating aggression and victimization among those participants in the experimental group in comparison to those in the control group. Also, the program will modify beliefs about love and other individual variables. However, and starting from previous literature, we expect to find higher effects on the reduction of dating aggression and victimization at medium term than at short-term (post-test wave).

Trial design

A cluster randomized control trial with two groups (experimental vs. control) and three waves (pre-test, post-test and follow-up) has been designed. The unit of randomization is the school and the framework will be the superiority of the experimental group in comparison to the control group after receiving the intervention.

Method

Study setting

The Dat-e Adolescence prevention program has been developed to be a universal program. For that reason, the program will be implemented in Secondary Public Schools from the South of Spain (Seville and Córdoba). Students attending these schools will receive the intervention.

Eligibility Criteria

Two Inclusion criteria are established: 1) all the schools should present a medium economic, social and cultural level (ISC Index in Spain) in accordance with the ranking established by the autonomous region's Education Authority; 2) the schools must be public or partially funded by the Regional Government.

Intervention

The program is based on the Dynamic Developmental Systems Model (17), which focuses on individual-environment interactions, where the presence of individual behaviours results by the interaction on personal risk factors, and the influences of distal and proximal risk factors that can vary across the development. Specifically, dating violence can be seen as the product of the interaction of different systems, as certain characteristics of the members of the dyad together with the couple's own relational dynamic (as conflicts) and peer and family factors.

By adopting this model, the program is designed to influence in some individual variables directly related to violence, as emotion regulation, self-esteem, beliefs and attitudes towards dating violence, the couple quality (including conflicts, conflict resolutions strategies and positive quality as intimacy), and peer group variables. We hypothesized that these individual variables could contribute to couple quality and, in turn, this couple quality could lead to face-to-face and online dating aggression and victimization.

The program is composed of a teacher sensitization module, a student curricular-based module composed of seven lessons (1 hour per week), and a peer-led program. The program will be implemented during the schools period in order to ensure the participation and continuity of students. Trained researchers will implement the program and a fidelity measure will be developed. A toolkit manual with all the units

and materials will be used (available upon request to the Principal Investigator).

Students received no rewards or incentives for taking part in the program.

Outcomes

In order to assess the efficacy of the program, different outcomes will be measured:

Behavioural Outcomes:

- Physical Aggression and Victimization (MCTS_R, 18):
- Psychological Aggression and Victimization (19):
- Online Aggression and Victimization (20):

Cognitive outcomes:

Myths of romantic love (adapted version of Myths of romantic love scale, 21)

- omnipotence myth
- jealousy myth
- better half myth
- eternal passion myth

Couple context outcomes:

- Conflicts (NRI, 22).
- Intimacy (Triangular Love Scale, 23).
- Online intimacy (CBD Q-A, 24).

Emotional outcomes:

- Anger regulation (EQ-YV, 25).
- Self-esteem (26):

Three waves are planned (a pre-test, a post-test one week after the intervention and 6 months follow-up is planned.). Self-measures using a pen-and-pencil procedure will be used during school time.

Sample size

Assuming a two-tailed test, $\alpha = .05$, an average intracluster correlation coefficient of $\rho = .01$ based on previous research in the area (27-28) and an average effect size of .35 according to previous meta-analyses that reported intervention effect sizes from .21 to .47 depending on the outcomes (29-30), we will need at least 7 schools (clusters) to ensure 80% power to detect a significant difference between the experimental and control groups.

It is planned to implement the program in a trial of around 2,000 students approx., with ages ranging from 12-16 years old.

Assignment of Intervention

Once 15 schools will be selected, a presentation letter will be sent to Principals. After that presentation letter, personal interviews are planned in order to explain the aims of the Project, its contents and procedure. These interviews will be held at each school prior to being allocated as control or experimental groups. A coin toss procedure is used to allocate schools in both groups. The research team will be in charge of this selection.

The waiting list procedure will be used for those schools allocated in the control group that will express interest in receiving intervention in future editions. Once allocated as control or experimental groups, school Principals will communicate the aims of the Project to families, teachers and School Board. An informed consent must be completed by families or/ school boards prior to participating in the study. Those

students that will refuse to participate will assist in alternative lessons within the school time.

In case of having more than two classes per grade in the schools, Principals will select the classes that will receive the intervention.

Data collection

Data will be collected in each school during school time. Pen and pencil self-reports will be used. Anonymous self-reports will be assured assigning the same and unique identification code to students in the three waves.

Data will be then coded in a statistical software by trained collaborators. Different seminars developed by the Principal Investigator will permit an accurate coding procedure. No participants' personal information will be coded, except for gender and age in order to assess the differential program efficacy on both, genders and ages.

Prior to the analysis, longitudinal measurement invariance will be tested for all the measures in the three waves.

Latent Change Score and Latent Growth Models will be used to predict longitudinal development and the effect of the intervention on the outcomes. The SPSS and M-PLUS software will be used.

Ethics and dissemination:

This protocol has been approved by the Research Ethics Committee of the Autonomous Region of Andalucía (code: 0575-N-14). Presentation letters and informed consent to

families, schools, teachers and over 18 years old students were included and approved by the Committee.

Results of the program assessment will be published in scientific journals. Toolkit manual is available upon request to the Principal Investigator. Once the efficacy will be assessed, the aim of the Project is to offer the program to the Educational government to be implemented by schools. No rewards or incentives will be received by the Research Team.

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